

| Arch Linux                                                            | ArchBang Linux                                                                          |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| No Xorg, Hal and D-Bus present.                                       | Xorg, Hal and D-Bus present.                                                            |
| No video, audio or other hardware drivers.                            | ALSA and most common set of video drivers provided.                                     |
| Huge user-base.                                                       | Relatively small user-base, as it is just four months old, but expanding exponentially. |
| Availability of official repositories and AUR (Arch User Repository). | Same here.                                                                              |
| Installation medium only, no Live mode.                               | Live CD as well as installable to hard disk or USB.                                     |
| Difficulty level: High                                                | Difficulty level: Medium                                                                |
| Rolling release.                                                      | Being based on Arch Linux, all fundamental properties are automatically inherited.      |
| Uses Grub-Legacy.                                                     | Uses Grub 1.97 [or Grub2].                                                              |
| Uses AIF (Arch Installation Framework).                               | Uses customised 2009.02 /arch/setup script.                                             |

Table 1: Point-by-point comparison between Arch Linux and ArchBang

(ALSA) and a working Openbox-based desktop environment that comes with an essential set of tools to get you started with your Arch Linux experience. Table 1 compares Arch Linux and ArchBang on a point-by-point basis.

### Why did we create yet another distribution?

Unlike thousands of distributions out there that are merely their parent distributions with changed name and artwork, plus re-packaging with a new colour, ArchBang is doing something that is highly appreciated by both novice and expert Linux users. Many novice users feel intimidated at the thought of building their own system with Arch Linux; hence ArchBang aims to provide the user with an easier alternative. This has shown results: a large number of novice Linux users who were afraid to take the leap into Arch Linux are gradually becoming interested in ArchBang. In fact, even expert users sometimes feel it's too time-consuming to set up the entire system from scratch, and hence prefer this alternative approach.

ArchBang is beneficial in many ways. Arch ISOs are released roughly twice a year, but that's not a general rule; in 2010, there has been no release so far! Thus, to install Arch, you have to use an outdated ISO image, with an outdated kernel, init scripts and everything else. While you can run *pacman -Syu* (*Pacman* is the Package Manager in Arch Linux) to update the system, this could be very confusing for new users. Just take the example of the new *mkinitcpio* changes from *klibc* to *busybox*. What do new users know about this? How will they decide when *Pacman* asks them to replace the older *klibc* packages? They obviously will be confused. ArchBang, on the other hand, solves these issues by providing a more updated system, with system maintenance and the changes to such vital files already done. This reduces user confusion.

It is always good to have an updated version of ISOs, even for a rolling-release distribution, since changes from

the last release are usually pretty massive, meaning a huge download for updates. While ArchBang currently has no *dist-upgrade* or version upgrade feature, the script is currently under development. Presently, ArchBang releases monthly testing ISO builds, aiming towards a 2010.09, i.e., a 'stable' final release in September. That said, since ArchBang is also a rolling-release distribution, a user can run the *Pacman* or *Packer* package manager to fetch the latest packages and stay updated, as they would in Arch Linux (but we don't encourage this for novice users—see below).

Since Arch Linux is a bleeding-edge distribution, it implies that often, packages are pushed out of the testing repository without hard-core testing. Unlike Slackware or Debian GNU/Linux, where the developers contribute towards most of the testing and sporadically push a stable product to users, Arch Linux relies on its own user-base for most of the testing. Hence, Arch is referred to as a "geek's distro", with the prevalent attitude being: "If you don't have the knowledge to fix the issues, then you shouldn't be using it." Imagine this: last night you were happily browsing from your Arch Linux system, and did a system upgrade. When you power on this morning, the system refuses to boot. The login manager might not appear, or maybe there's no X—or worse, there's a kernel panic! Pin-pointing the exact cause is often not easy, specially if you're not a pro! This could have occurred due to many reasons—a new kernel upgrade, a video driver upgrade, or a Xorg upgrade.

So now you have to lose precious time trying to fix these issues before you can log in and use your computer. Worse, rolling back package updates is often not a smooth process for Arch Linux, as it often leads to dependency hell. You then not only need to track down a repository with an outdated earlier package, but also find all of its outdated dependencies.

ArchBang tries to provide users with current but stable software, by first testing it. We recently set our target and versioning scheme—our product version will be in the format